
Ancient Board Games in perspective

Papers from the 1990 British Museum colloquium,
with additional contributions

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Board Games in Perspective

An Introduction

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In September 1990, a three-day Colloquium entitled *Board Games in the Ancient World* took place in the British Museum. It was, apparently, the first of its kind: the recruitment of speakers and participants turned out to be a complex matter for a subject that hardly existed at all as an academic research field. Researchers knew of one another's publications but had rarely met as individuals. In the end perhaps one hundred people – including speakers – assembled in London for papers covering a wide range of topics. A small exhibition, optimistically entitled *Games of the World* and largely drawn from British Museum collections, was set up for the Colloquium, and ran thereafter for several months.

The papers finally published in the present volume represent the majority but not the entirety of those delivered at the original conference. In addition, certain additional papers have been solicited by the editor to give the projected volume greater breadth.¹ The overall aim both of the conference and the publication was to report on new research, although the intervening years have seen an unanticipated flourishing in board game studies that has meant much fertile progress in many directions.

Historically speaking, board games have scarcely received the attention they deserve from historians, anthropologists or sociologists, as well as many other fields with which their study overlaps. There has been a general tendency, say in archaeological excavation reports, to lump games together with toys, with the implicit conclusion that they are all somehow 'childish', or at least the domain of children. In fact, before the modern phenomenon of commercial board games in the eighteenth century, games played on boards with dice and pieces were mainly the concern of adults and not children at all. As a consequence there is no university post concerned directly with board game studies as a discipline, although individual teachers have incorporated something of what it has to offer in other programmes (see, for example, Avedon/Sutton-Smith 1971).

Scholars have been wrestling with the definition of 'game' and 'games' for years, and in some ways the wrestling doesn't really help; a illuminating overview here is Parlett 2004. But the truth is that everyone knows what board games are. They are a brilliant invention that has given pleasure and excitement to people all over the world since time immemorial, and can be reckoned, on the whole, a beneficial discovery. Games have usually been meant for fun and entertainment, often using devices of ingenuity and beauty, as has been celebrated in particular in Lhôte 1994 and Mackenzie/Finkel (eds) 2004.

It is not an easy matter to point to a society, ancient or modern, where no kind of board game has been – or is – played. Games played on boards are truly an ancient institution. The first archaeological examples come from a handful of pre-pottery Neolithic sites in the Middle East dating from around 7000 BC. From the context of their discovery, it is evident that their appearance on the stage of human social evolution coincides with the development of structured and sedentary communal living, associated with shared responsibility and labour. It is under these circumstances that *leisure* first makes itself apparent, and it is surely leisure that is the prime requirement for the invention and play of board games. In India, there is a prime and eloquent word for this, namely 'time-pass'. It has probably always been largely *time-pass* that has governed the role of board games in the world. With these earliest game boards, so remote in time and so far in advance of historical record, we can have no understanding of how they might have been used, although to some scholars it is hard entirely to disassociate them from boards for the far later historical mancala family of counting games, treated elsewhere in this book.

Over the ages good and bad games alike have appeared, just as they still do. The good ones survive, evolve and, above all, spread. A useful analogy is a dropped bottle of milk; the milk runs freely everywhere into the most unreachable places, and it is much the same with board games. Occasionally a church or government has tried to outlaw a particular game, but never with success. In fact, games spread from culture to culture in a way that has hardly any parallel. They exist on a level impervious to religion or politics, and represent a free means of communication between people that nothing can successfully interrupt. The mechanisms whereby games move across borders can only sometimes be traced. Obvious possibilities are invading soldiers or mercenaries, merchants or sailors, all of whom carry their own games with them, and encounter strange ones abroad. Knowledge of both equipment and play can be carried in the head and transmitted with minimal language, and it is in this way that the most successful of the world's games have seeped about the globe, ending up in public prominence or obscure corners as the case might be.

Two primary problems that concern the would-be board-game historian are origins, both of the general phenomenon and of specific games, and transmission. Board games *in toto* can readily be seen to embody primal and thus universal human preoccupations: the battle, the hunt, the race,

¹ These include the contributions by John Fairbairn, John Fritz and David Gibson, Michael Mark, Nicholas Purcell, Edgar Pusch, Ian

Riddler, Laurence Russ, Grigori Semenov, Micaela Soar and Jurgen Stigter. Andrew Lo has contributed a second paper.

organisation, and counting. Fortune telling with dice or systems of calendrical reckoning and other activities can share their formal paraphernalia with game apparatus, and indeed it seems probable that their remote histories must often have been intertwined and complementary. In other cases a more prosaic background seems clear, such as those simple games where one or two powerful forces (tigers, lions, or elephants) are pitched against numerous weaker animals (goats, sheep, or human soldiers) without the use of dice. All games of this class share the common principle that the powerful can 'kill', or 'take', the weaker by jumping over them in a straight line to a vacant square beyond. It is not over-fanciful to suggest that the first versions of such games were developed by shepherds guarding their flocks from predators, and it is sure that their concept and nature derive directly from a universal and ageless activity (see here Averbakh 1995). On the other hand, games of the mancala family have been plausibly seen ultimately to embody ritual in symbolising the planting of seed; the most fluent exposition of this view and the transformations that the mechanism underwent is that of the scholar Wim van Binsbergen, whose wide-ranging 1997 paper on the subject will remain important reading.

For the very earliest periods, of course, there are few examples and no written evidence to help the investigator. From the third millennium BC onwards there are often numerous examples of playing objects, with, as time goes on, the increasing benefit of inscriptions and even rules. However, in antiquity and for most of the time since, board game inventors (if individual inventors there were) have remained anonymous. Tackling the spread of a particular game is, therefore, often treacherous. As is clear from major papers in this volume, the origins even of chess or backgammon, two of the world's most successful board games (judged by distribution, longevity, and number of contemporary adherents), are still largely obscure or debated, and new evidence is needed. The problem is even more extreme with lesser games, those of elementary structure but often of comparable geographical and chronological distribution, such as Nine Men's Morris.

In addition, people have usually played games using natural items that are readily to hand. Boards can be scratched on stone, burnt into wood, or even drawn on the ground for a single game. Sometimes, in other words, there is no 'board' at all. Pieces, likewise, can be seeds or pebbles, twigs or small balls of dung. Historically speaking, ornate boards and pieces made out of expensive materials by craftsmen have always been a rarity. The humble and the poor make their games for free, although it sometimes happens that really good games are played by everybody in society, and collecting specimens of cheap and exotic examples side by side can tell us a good deal about people's lives in both the ancient and modern worlds. Where games have been played with natural bits and pieces they will not usually survive to be identified by archaeologists. In Malaya, for example, simple chessmen are cut from tender shoots of bamboo, and captured men can be chewed up on the spot. In India, on the other hand, many traditional games are played on decorated cloth boards, which tend to be targeted by hungry insects, and so boards rarely survive from early times

to help us fill in the picture, as is clear from Andrew Topsfield's 1985 history of Snakes and Ladders in India. This means that tracing the long history of board games cannot always be accomplished with convenient evidence, and, as we shall see, games historians sometimes have to make courageous leaps in their investigations.

Even making the assumption that games have usually functioned for relaxation and pleasure does not mean that things have always been so simple. Individual games have periodically been used for training in war or diplomacy, or education in mathematics or logic, and even for political propaganda, but it can still be argued that these have always been specific and localised offshoots of the original more lighthearted underlying function.

The problems in understanding transmission can be very complex. Identical or closely similar board games turn up in very disparate parts of the world, often using an idiosyncratic board shape or design which seems to represent independent invention, although no-one has ever dared to postulate criteria by which independence rather than imitation should be attributed to a particular linear design, or the rules that go with it. In contrast a single game on a clearly-defined board in closely adjacent villages can exhibit strongly divergent rules. Some sense of this emerges from studies published here, but documentation of such phenomena is in its infancy, and satisfactory explanations of the underlying processes have hardly even been considered. Language distribution, historical (or prehistoric) population movement or migration and even DNA will all have their part to play in reconstruction. The collection of primary data in the field by individuals or teams is a laborious and often costly process. A revealing example of single-handed work carried out on mancala games by Vernon Eagle in Yunnan province in China was described by him in 1995. The British Museum has been collaborating for some years with the Anthropological Survey of India in Calcutta in an ongoing programme to investigate traditional board games across rural India; the results of the first season's investigations, including a typology of all known Indian game boards, are currently in press. For those interested in previous work of this kind, the reprints published in Ray and Ghosh 1999 can be recommended. Recent and protracted research carried out by Maurício Lima and his colleagues among the indigenous Indian tribes of the Brazilian Amazon has produced startling results, as already indicated in the volume entitled *O Jogo da Onça* (Lima/Barreto 2004). Crucial fieldwork of this nature could well be encouraged in many parts of the world in view of the consistent erosion of traditional activities (of which games are but one) in non-urban societies, which all too often reveal themselves to be under threat from a variety of contemporary factors.

In the early 1990s, when the British Museum Colloquium was still a recent memory, board game research was characteristically scattered and isolated. The existing literature was very diverse, and synthesis to a large extent had not moved on from the handful of classic studies that had held sway for decades. The earliest such publication was the work of Thomas Hyde (1632–1702), Oxford Professor of Hebrew and Arabic and court interpreter to three successive kings of England, who used his unrivalled opportunities in dealing with foreign ambassadors and emissaries to

document their traditional board games. These researches culminated in the remarkable histories of chess and backgammon and many other games (Hyde 1689 and 1694), which would still profit from a full translation into a modern language. The recent publication of the unsuspected seventeenth-century game book of Francis Willughby (Cram/Forggeng/Johnston 2003) has revealed that Hyde was not alone in his interests.

The next major contributor was the American Robert Stewart Culin (1858–1929), a curator both in the Museum of Archaeology and Paleontology, University of Philadelphia, and the Brooklyn Museum, and a far-seeing and effective early museum anthropologist. He is the only early researcher to form the subject of a paper in the present volume. Certain of Culin's theories have been discredited, discarded, or derided, but the richness of the primary information he collected and published in such classics as *Korean Games*, *Chess and Playing Cards*, or *Games of the North American Indians*, is completely without a rival, and it is a rash researcher who fails to consider the research or the collections of gaming equipment that represent Culin's legacy.

Much of the latter's writing, as well as Edward Falkener's idiosyncratic study of 1892, was supplanted by H. J. R. Murray's scholarly but dessicated compilation *A History of Board Games Other than Chess*, which appeared in 1952, and remained hard to find until it was recently reprinted. This was the first modern work to attempt a classification of the games of the world at large between the covers of one book, and represented a lifetime's collection of material culled from archaeological, historical, anthropological, and other sources. In addition to installing method and breadth of approach Murray also bequeathed his fivefold division of board games as a structure for research and classification, namely:

- 1 Games of alignment and configuration (e.g. Noughts and Crosses)
- 2 War games (e.g. chess)
- 3 Hunt games (e.g. Fox and Geese)
- 4 Race games (e.g. Pachisi)
- 5 Mancala games

This system, which is admittedly not free of drawbacks, has in more recent times been reappraised and criticised, by R. C. Bell in Bell 1979 and later works, and most productively perhaps by D. Parlett in 1999, a highly readable work that embraces a similar scope to Murray's, with much new information and insights. In fact the issue of classification is still one that provokes lively altercation.

At the time of going to press the study of board games can be seen to have undergone over the last twenty years or so a

remarkable and unanticipated burgeoning. For example, a regular sequence of conferences entitled *Board Games in Academia* has followed upon the original London meeting that led to the present book, engendering its own journal *Board Games Studies*, which has now reached volume 7.² As research moves onwards, questions and new lines of enquiry seem, if anything, to proliferate.

Within the British Museum itself the original conference has had further direct consequences. One was the augmented collecting of specimen board games for the various departmental collections, generously funded by the British Museum Society, now the Friends of the British Museum. An ongoing programme of acquisition has brought in objects ancient and modern, rare and ephemeral, in sufficient quantity to form the core of a travelling exhibition entitled *Across the Board: Around the World in 18 Games*, which is, at the time of writing, half-way through a series of six venues in the British Isles.³

Adequate coverage of the world's important board games, even those before the modern period, can never be achieved in a single volume of papers such as this. Among traditional and widespread games it should be pointed out that those played on cruciform boards, such as the Patolli of ancient Mexico (Kendall 1980) or Indian Pachisi (Finkel 2004b), or the mysterious ancient Chinese game of Liubo (Mackenzie 2004) have found little more than a mention.

As shown in this book, the history of individual board games is often romantic and unexpected. While most people play board games as children – if not adults – few indeed know anything of the history of those games, and are often surprised to learn that they are many centuries old, or even imports from very remote places. Board games are, however, a great unifier of mankind, and an examination of the games of the world *en bloc* carries within it a clear message: they surely represent a human and understandable universal.

Apologia

Board Games in Perspective has been a deplorable time coming into focus. Conceivably it could be a contender for acknowledgement as the Longest-Delayed Conference Volume, although such prestigious awards should never be officially bestowed without exhaustive research. The range of contributing faults that are responsible is *entirely that of the editor*, and deep-felt apology is here tendered to all the contributors, patient and impatient. I hope that this book will nevertheless prove to be of interest and use to them, and other readers too.

² These developments are in large measure due to the energy and vision of Dr Alexander J de Voogt. The post-London conferences have been Leiden (1995 and 1997); Florence (1999); Fribourg (2001); Barcelona (2002); Marburg (2003); Philadelphia (2004) and Oxford (2005). The journal has provided a platform for a great deal of recent and important board game research, and includes many of the papers from the various conferences. Interested readers might consult www.boardgamesstudies.org both for future conferences and the publication.

³ The host museums involved are Segedunum Roman Fort and Museum; Royal Albert Memorial Museum, Exeter; Gosport Museum, Hampshire; New Walk Museum & Gallery, Leicester; Lincoln City and County Museum and Luton Museum. The core

display has been a selection of Lewis chessmen, surrounded by games of many types from many cultures. The exhibition was funded by the Department of Culture, Media and Sport, the Department for Education and Skills, and the National/Regional Museum Partnerships Programme for Education 2004/2006. It has sought to demonstrate how games travel and survive, how the same games appear in disparate parts of the world, and how games taken for granted in homes in Britain often have a long and ornate history. Two British Museum publications were published to accompany the exhibition, Robinson 2004 and Finkel 2004a, and a wide-ranging educational programme focusing on board games has been developed.

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